Lesson 4: How far did the Titanic disaster have an impact on the world?

Summary of Lesson

Objectives:

1. To make inferences from historical sources about the local and national impact of the Titanic disaster.
2. To analyse the impact on sailing and shipping by identifying changes over time.

This lesson will be focusing on the impact the Titanic disaster had on a local, national and international level, utilising the concepts of change and continuity and also source analysis. The lesson begins by looking at the impact it had on the city of Southampton, as well as including national links such as charity fundraising that the people of the UK supported. From this, students will predict what they think would change after the sinking of the Titanic thinking about its impact. To test these predictions, students will analyse the change and continuity to shipping by looking at legal developments regarding safety measures as well as looking at other disasters. Students should be able to evaluate that although there was considerable change to shipping on an international level, disasters still occur due to human error, unexpected conditions and naturally occurring faults.

National Curriculum Links

This lesson links to the National Curriculum aims of:

- gain historical perspective by placing their growing knowledge into different contexts, understanding the connections between local, regional, national and international history
- pupils to understand the process of change
- identify significant events, make connections, draw contrasts (focusing on the concepts of change and continuity).

If in the local area to Southampton or another Titanic site, this lesson provides the opportunity for students to study a local history study linking to the:

- challenges for Britain, Europe and the Wider World 1901 to the present day.

Resources Required

- Lesson PowerPoint
- Resource 1: Images 1-6
- Resource 2: Source worksheet
- Resource 3: Information cards
- Resource 4: Line of change and continuity

Lesson Guidance

Step 1: There is an image of a cheque made out to the Titanic Relief Fund for £1 and 10s. Ask students to make some inferences from the source about the impact of the Titanic being aware that some students may not know what a cheque is. Use probing questions to draw out ideas. Reveal the provenance of the source: a cheque donated to the Titanic Relief Fund, a national charity set up following the disaster to support the families and victims of the sinking. The donation of £1 and 10s, is around the equivalent of £120 so a sizeable donation has been made. Here you can further probe the students about what this reveals about the impact of the Titanic raising ideas about people's feelings towards supporting the relief fund, you could draw comparisons here with charities that people donate to and why (Children in Need, Race for Life etc).

Step 2: This task is to make inferences from historical sources about the local and national impact of the Titanic disaster.

Explain to the students that they are going to use images from the Sea City Museum in Southampton, to explore how Southampton and the UK reacted to the disaster to identify the impact it had at the time. Questions to use are below:

1. Does the source show Immediate/short term/long term impact?
2. Local or national

3. What can we learn about the impact it had on Southampton and the UK?

Use Source 1 as a modelled example. Students can then work independently looking at the other sources and grasping an understanding of the impact that the Titanic had on both the local and national level.

After the source analysis, question students about their findings from the sources. What have they revealed about the impact of the Titanic? What might be the consequences of these? These questions may also be useful to use during the source task to challenge students and/or prompt their thinking.

Example questions:

- The date on the cheque is 1917, what does that reveal to us?
- If there were husbands lost, what did this mean for the families left behind?
- What does the clothing of the people in source 3 reveal to us about the impact and expectations of news?
- A football match had its date moved - why might they have moved the date?

Students should get the idea that the main impact of the Titanic was the loss of life in the city and that there was huge national support for raising money and to memorialise those that were lost.

Step 3: Following their analysis of the impact of the disaster, students are going to look at what the enquiries suggested should change to avoid another disaster. To begin this analysis, ask students: With the impact of the Titanic stretching across the UK, what changes do you think there would be after the disaster?

Following their ideas show them the recommendations that were made. These are a brief summary for students but further information can be found at https://www.titanicinquiry.org/

Using the recommendations identified, students should analyse what changes have taken place since the Titanic disaster and what has continued. Provide students with a set of information cards. Students are going to use a line of change and continuity to look at how sailing and shipping has or has not changed over time. Ask them to read the information and place the information cards along the line according to the level of change and continuity.

When modelling the task, probe students with the following questions:

Example questions

- Does the event show change or continuity?
- If change - is it considerable change?
- Is it law or a recommendation?
- Is it national or international?
- How might this impact on the change it could have?
- Have things really changed over time- has anything stayed the same?
- What continuities can you find? Why are there still continuities with disasters? What themes come from the events that show there are continuities?

Students should be able to identify that safety measures and technology has changed since the disaster, and that laws to improve safety have been made. They should also be able to evaluate that this does not always work in practice and that disasters still happen for different reasons. After completion, pose the question: 'What does this new information tell us about the impact of the Titanic?'

Final step: This plenary is for students to finalise their evaluations on the change and continuity that the Titanic disaster has had on shipping. Students can do this in a number of ways depending on the time allocated.

1. Students could complete a formal piece of writing on their findings about the impact (locally, nationally or internationally) or their views on change and continuity producing an explanation on their view.
2. Students could explain their position with regards to how far they agree there was change. This could be done verbally, physically or written.
3. Students could be introduced to more philosophical questioning or discussions around disaster, such as "Why could the lessons learnt from the Titanic not prevent further disasters".